

fresh fashion. And herein lies the appeal for the buyers. Priya Kishore of avant-garde Mumbai store Bombay Electric has in the past picked up new designers and is looking forward to a new season of style. "Fashion weeks are a great place to spot new designers. But very few of them make the final cut on account of lack of finish and professionalism," says Kishore.

That's where Chopra and IMG Fashion hope to bring their creative counselling into play. "IMG carried out a number of campus outreach programmes to scout for talent and our efforts have been successfully

rewarded," says Raizada.

With veteran Rodricks set to style and choreograph the GenNext show for a second season and international stylists Kelvin Harries and Scardino providing their perspective to the rest of the couture club, the event is striving to become an incubator for fresh talent. "It helps when an informed eye adds a new dimension to your collection. The stylist becomes the first objective point of reference," says Barve.

Foreign stylists apart, the fashion week is set to strengthen its buyers' list with Tiziana Cardini of La Rinascente readying to explore the Mumbai mart after her Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week sojourn last year. Pamela Easton and Lydia Pearson of Australian brand Easton Pearson will also be

scouring the style set. "In our effort to define the future of fashion we will also have a designer exchange programme with trade show Coterie, New York. Elyse Kroll producer of Coterie will attend LFW too," says Raizada. Additionally, IMG's expert eyes are also set to be on the lookout for potential models and will give the young clotheshorses a chance to grab a slice of the global pie.

The fresh frat also brings with it a unique perspective. While Dayal's "trans-season" collection Clover, where "super nature meets city and settles in a resort", a series of short dresses and kaftans, draw their inspiration from the clover, silk cotton tree and other forest essentials. Barve plays with sculptural shapes, textural pleats and layers. Kaushie Adiseshan's Retro in the Metro brings the allure of Madhubala and Audrey Hepburn to a flirty line with cinched waists and geometric prints. Drashta Sarvaiya, fast gaining a reputation as designer to

the stars, will present an individualistic line

Confession where cocktail dresses and creatively draped saris hark back "to the Madonna-esque era when unconventional ruled the roost".

Even as new designers prepare to unveil their collections, they will again be sharing their ramp razzmatazz with retail brands like Allen Solly, Portico and Park Avenue, which are also poised to present catwalk collections. Ask if these retail brands will overshadow the week's prêt proceedings and Raizada says, "Retail brands showcasing at a fashion event is in fact a snapshot of changing India." But whether the retail route LFW has taken misfires or works, only subsequent seasons will tell.

While fashion is not fashion without the frills, and at some point Bollywood will add to the brouhaha, trend watchers will have their peepers trained on the new prêt lot, hoping they will lift this Mumbai melee to a new fashion high. ■

Rakesh Agarwal
Techno-fabrics meet leather in this futuristic line called Art Graphisme

Anupama & Dayal
Flower power meets city and gets shaped into dresses and dhoti pants in Clover

Kaushie Adiseshan
Defined waists and flirty dresses pay homage to Madhubala in Retro in the Metro

Nachiket Barve
In his collection, luxurious metallic hues meet clean shapes

Priya & Chintan
Drapes and prints blend to take the shape of saris, skirts and dresses

